

The WONDER YEAR

By Sharda Ugra

There will never be another year like it. Before 2008, Indian sport could only wonder—and lament over its wretched *kismet*. Before 2008, there were fables of so-near-and-yet-so-far and hard-luck tales of if-only. Before 2008, we always hoped but didn't quite know what to believe. But this is the year when everything changed and which has changed everything. This is a year that ripped up a sorry history book, that altered India's expectations from its athletes and the scale of the athlete's own ambition. That sent a mighty hammer through a ceiling. That, actually, sent a

lead pellet weighing 5.3 milligrammes from an air-rifle on a journey across 10 metres. The journey ended in the time it took for India to blink, the pellet found the bulls-eye and reduced an impregnable barrier into a waterfall of clinking glass shards. This was the year India discovered that it was possible for its athletes, despite every limitation, hurdle, handicap and disappointment to find a way to the top of their world.

For all the grief 2008 otherwise brought to a nation at incessant argument with its many selves, this was the year sport gave India enough occasion for unqualified celebration—across disciplines in an Olympic year. Over and above everything else that happened, 2008 was the year Indian sport was set free.

It may seem like too tall a claim to make on the back of what eventually were just three Olympic medals—India's first

individual gold and two bronzes—in shooting, boxing and wrestling. It is not as if our ranges and our rings are suddenly filled with countless young itching to compete. If Vijender Singh and R.P. Singh walked into a mall together, there is little doubt who would be more sought after. Yet, none of that matters.

The real resonance from 2008, its real power, will be heard and understood by young athletes just starting out. They will remember the story of Abhinav Bindra saving his best shot for the last and understand the quality of skill and fibre of nerve it needs to win an Olympic gold. They will hear about Susheel Kumar winning three bouts in 90 minutes and learn about strength. They will look at Vijender Singh and know more about speed. This is the year about which we will hear more in the years to come.

Maybe this was the way it

was meant to be: just as hockey, once India's Olympic passport, expired quietly in faraway Chile, others stepped in. Bindra's rifle-shot will echo in immortality. India has found new folk heroes in its lippy, confident boxers. Everyone now knows what 'repechage' means. And that Saina and Sania are two different people.

The Beijing Olympics may have lasted all of two weeks but their afterglow lit up avenues for Indian athletes in unfashionable disciplines. They will still have to deal with the power-crazy and the ignorant whose numbers still dominate their administration, but Beijing has become their beacon, proof that the Olympic standard is within reach.

Before Beijing, bantamweight Akhil Kumar said, "The first medal is just a barrier—if it breaks once, boxing will get India medals in every Olympics." Since Beijing, box-